

Week 1 Lecture Notes

Literature Review Methodologies

Summer 2026 EDCI 59100-016 DIS

Synthesized from downloaded Brightspace webpages

This note combines the visible teaching content from the Week 1 intro page and the methodology comparison guide. It is organized for study use and is not a word-for-word transcript.

1. Introduction to Literature-Based Research and Review Methodologies

Literature reviews are presented in the course as a rigorous form of research, not just a summary of prior studies. Over the course, the goal is to develop a substantial literature review manuscript on a topic connected to your research interests.

The opening material introduces five major review methodologies:

- Narrative review
- Integrative review
- Theoretical review
- Scoping review
- Systematic review

The first instructional video is meant to give a general understanding of these approaches and how they differ. At this stage, students are not expected to have already chosen a final methodology.

2. Fit for Purpose

The central idea in Week 1 is fit for purpose. The best methodology is the one that aligns with the research purpose, the question being asked, and the contribution the review is intended to make.

There is no single best review methodology. Each one serves a different purpose. The course materials emphasize that the task is to compare approaches carefully and identify which one is the strongest match for the topic, the question, and the intended outcome.

Key takeaway:

- Start with the purpose of the review.
- Match the review type to the question.
- Consider what kind of contribution you want the review to make.

3. How to Review the Comparison Guide

The comparison guide asks students to pay attention to:

- the purpose of each methodology,
- the kinds of questions each method supports,
- how structured the search and selection process is,

- the usual outcome or contribution,
- the strengths and limitations, and
- the situations where each methodology is most appropriate.

Students are also encouraged to reflect on their own project and think about which methodologies appear to align with their topic and goals.

4. Methodology Comparison at a Glance

The guide presents review types on a spectrum. Real-world articles may blend approaches, so the most important question is not the label alone, but how the review is actually designed and carried out.

Method	Primary Purpose	Best Use	Search / Selection Style	Typical Outcome
Narrative	Summarize and interpret existing literature	Broad topic exploration	Flexible and selective	Broad overview and interpretation
Integrative	Synthesize across diverse empirical and theoretical sources	Understanding patterns and trends	Structured but flexible	New insights or conceptual frameworks
Theoretical	Examine, refine, or develop theory	Refining or critiquing theory	Focused, concept-driven	Theory development or clarification
Scoping	Map the extent and nature of literature	New or emerging topics	Broad and inclusive	Identification of trends and gaps
Systematic	Answer a focused research question	Evidence-based decision making	Highly systematic and reproducible	Evidence-based conclusions

5. What the Guide Says to Watch For

Review methodologies can overlap. A review may have features of more than one type, so the guide advises students to prioritize three things:

- the purpose of the article,
- the level of methodological structure, and
- how the literature is selected and synthesized.

The comparison table also highlights that some reviews may look similar to other types on the surface. For example, a narrative review can be broad and descriptive, while a scoping review can look somewhat systematic because it maps the field in a structured way.

6. Strengths and Limitations

The guide summarizes the main strengths and limitations of the five approaches.

- Narrative reviews are flexible and useful for early exploration, but they may be less transparent and more open to bias.
- Integrative reviews can combine diverse evidence and generate new insights, but they can become inconsistent if they are not clearly structured.
- Theoretical reviews support deep conceptual work and theory development, but they may not capture the full empirical depth of a topic.
- Scoping reviews are valuable for identifying gaps and clarifying a research landscape, but they provide less depth in synthesis.
- Systematic reviews are the most structured and reproducible, but they are time-intensive and require strict procedures.

7. Typical Publication Types

The guide notes that review methodologies commonly appear in different kinds of publications:

- Narrative reviews often appear as stand-alone review articles, introductory conceptual pieces, book chapters, or dissertation background sections.
- Integrative reviews often appear as review articles, conceptual framework papers, dissertation chapters, or research agenda papers.
- Theoretical reviews often appear as theory development articles, conceptual papers, or scholarly essays.
- Scoping reviews often appear as review articles, preliminary studies that justify future systematic reviews, research agenda papers, or policy-oriented reports.
- Systematic reviews often appear as stand-alone evidence synthesis articles, health and social science reviews, policy reports, dissertation chapters, or clinical practice guidelines with extra evidence evaluation.

8. Practical Study Note

The most useful way to work with these materials is to start with your topic and ask:

- What do I want this review to accomplish?
- Is my question broad and exploratory, or narrow and focused?
- Do I need mapping and gap identification, or do I need strict evidence synthesis?

- Which method matches the scope of literature I can realistically review?

For many student projects, the first useful decision is often between scoping and systematic review. Scoping review is a strong fit when the topic is broad, emerging, or multidisciplinary. Systematic review is a stronger fit when the question is narrow and the evidence base is ready for strict screening and synthesis.

9. Source Pages Included

- Intro. to Literature Review Methodologies
- Methodology Comparison Guide